minister Piyush Goyal, who saw the film at a special screening in Delhi on October 22, enough for him to take action against such institutes. The very next day, the government sent notices to 20 coaching firms for issuing misleading advertisements, and slapped fines on four others.

As a film, *12th Fail* is a project Chopra has invested a lot of himself in, drawing on some of his own experiences. "Like Manoj, my belongings too were stolen when I came to Mumbai. There was a struggle to survive but I relied on hard work and resilience," he says (see interview). "My wife keeps telling me, '*Koi nahin sun raha tera bhashan*' (no one cares for your sermons). It doesn't stop me. I just restart, like Manoj." Staying honest to his core beliefs is important to Chopra. "Manoj is referred to as a bloody idiot. I am that bloody idiot also." No wonder that after seeing the film, Shah, also Chopra's batchmate at the Film & Television Institute of India in Pune, messaged to say the filmmaker had finally learned direction. For Chopra, that's validation enough.

With the movie out for release, Chopra's Santacruz office, appointed with Kashmiri handicrafts, is buzzing with activity. The India vs Pakistan World Cup tie plays on an employee's laptop. Chopra keeps an eye on the score (his son, Agni Dev, is a Ranji-level player) even as he keeps track of the film's post production. Muffin, one of the 11 dogs Chopra has, moves about with a ball. "I have had a love-hate relationship with the film frater-



He made us believe that make the film you want to make and not what others want you to make

–RAJKUMAR HIRANI
Filmmaker



INTERVIEW / VIDHU VINOD CHOPRA

"To pause is to perish"

In an exclusive interview, **VIDHU VINOD CHOPRA** reflects on his cinematic journey, the struggles he faced to get here and, having arrived, where he goes from here. Excerpts

Q. You've said that you didn't direct *12th Fail* but were the instrument the universe chose to tell this true, against-all-odds story of IPS officer Manoj Kumar Sharma.

This is the only film [about which] I have felt like this. This one is stylistically different from what I have done. Things just happened. I wrote it over three years, the prep was a year and a half and then we took 38 days to shoot it. We shot in a village in Chambal under immense pressure as there was a threat from dacoits and the police had to give us protection. There were scenes in real locations in Mukherjee Nagar [New Delhi] with big crowds. I directed it with an iron hand, screaming my heart out for it. I have given four years of my life. I genuinely believe this film will change lives.

Martin Scorsese famously said 'The personal is universal'. You say Manoj's story is akin to yours. How so?

When I came to Mumbai, like Manoj, I too had my belongings stolen. There was a struggle to survive, but I banked on hard work and resilience. I have incorporated a line from my everyday